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Asiwaju Bola Ahmed Tinubu is the current leader of Nigeria. He assumed office on May 29, 2023. He won the presidential election held on February 25, 2023, under the platform of the All Progressives Congress (APC). Before his presidency, Tinubu served as the Governor of Lagos State from 1999 to 2007. He is renowned for his political acumen and is often referred to as the "Jagaban" of the political landscape in Nigeria

The president of Nigeria is President Asiwaju Bola Ahmed Tinubu.

A total of 29 state governors have reportedly spent N1.994tn on recurrent expenditures, which include refreshments, sitting allowances, travelling, and utilities in the first nine months of 2024, PUNCH reports.

Istates obtained a N533.29bn loan, while it spent N658.93bn to service its debts owed to local, foreign, and multilateral creditors.

However, these states fell short in their revenue-generating targets, collecting a total sum of N1.92tn as internally generated revenue but fell short of the revenue target of N2.868tn, recording a deficit of N948.28bn.The recurrent data utilised in this report did not include personnel costs.

An analysis of the fiscal performance of each state, utilizing data from the Q1 to Q3 budget performance reports obtained from each state’s website, revealed a pressing need for stringent measures to prioritise fiscal discipline, especially amidst growing calls to reduce the costs of governance.

This comes despite a 40 per cent increase in the state’s statutory allocations from the Federation Account.

For the first three quarters of the year, our correspondent examined budget implementation data from twenty-nine states; data for six states was not available.

Borno, Gombe, Kaduna, Kano, Kwara, Sokoto, and Ogun states were the ones without the latest data from January to September 2024.

Since the commencement of the current administration, state governments have enjoyed improved monthly allocation mainly due to the elimination of fuel subsidies and the unification of the foreign exchange market.

The Nigeria Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative recently noted that the Federation Accounts Allocation Committee disbursed N3.473tn to the three tiers of government in the second quarter of 2024.

This reflects an increase of N46.77bn (1.42 per cent) compared to the first quarter of 2024.

The Federal Government received N1.102tn, representing 33.35 per cent of the total allocation, while 36 states received N1.337tn (40.47 per cent), and the 774 local government councils shared N864.98bn (26.18 per cent).

A comparison with the previous quarter shows that the Federal Government's allocation decreased by N41.44bn (3.76 per cent), while state governments saw an increase of N58.13bn (4.29 per cent), and local government councils experienced a rise of N30.82bn (3.57 per cent).

But this improved funding hasn't translated to an improved standard of living for its citizens.

A breakdown showed that the 29-state government spent N1.994tn on its recurrent expenditure, which included refreshments for guests, sitting allowances to government officials, local and foreign travel expenses, and utility bills.

The general utilities include electricity, internet, telephone charges, water rates, and sewerage charges, among others.

Lagos, Plateau, and Delta States spent the highest on their operating expenses, incurring a cost of N375.19bn, N144.87bn, and N121.54bn, respectively. This was followed by Ondo and Bauchi spending N107.34bn and N99.31bn.

Niger State, under the leadership of Governor Mohammed Umar Bago, was the highest borrower within the review period, obtaining loans worth N79.09bn. Katsina followed with a loan of N72.89bn. Oyo State also got a loan of N62.48bn.

In terms of revenue, Lagos State collected the highest of N912.17bn, followed by Rivers State with a collection of N269.18bn. Third on the list was Delta (N97.02bn).

A state-by-state analysis revealed that Abia State, led by Governor Alex Otti, spent N17.91bn on operating expenses and generated N22.15bn in revenue, falling short of the N32.14bn revenue target. Additionally, the state borrowed N3.901bn and allocated N10.91bn for debt servicing.

Adamawa State spent N41.45bn on recurrent expenditure, while it earned N9.16bn income out of its revenue of N22.24bn. This state borrowed N10bn and paid N22.68bn to service its debts.

Akwa-Ibom State recurrent spending reached N85.45bn in nine months, N43.98bn more than its generated revenue of N41.47bn in nine months. The state paid N34.47bn as debt service but didn't borrow.

Anambra State generated more revenue (N28.296bn) than its recurrent spending of N12.70bn. It spent N4.56bn on debt service and didn’t record any borrowing.

The Bauchi government spent N99.31bn on its operating expenses. This state only got N15.92bn out of its budgeted target of N37.03bn, but borrowed N33.64bn and paid N27.54bn as debt service.

Bayelsa state got N57.85bn IGR more than its revenue target of N23.87bn. It spent N75.23bn on its operating costs and spent N30.54bn on its debt service.

Governor Hyacinth Alia of Benue state approved the spending of N29.45bn for operating expenses while it collected N8.71bn as revenue out of an N23.91bn target. This state didn’t borrow but spent N5.48bn to service previous loans collected.

Similarly, Cross Rivers spent N55.73bn on recurring expenses, collected N32.42bn IGR, borrowed N20.67bn from its creditors and spent N19.99bn on debt service.

Delta state recurrent expenditure reached N121.54bn in nine months while it earned N97.02bn as revenue out of the N110.3bn target. The oil-rich state serviced its debt with N55.9bn and didn’t obtain any loan.

Also, Ebonyi State spent N37.73bn on its recurrent expenses but earned N15.67bn as revenue. The state borrowed N15.65bn and spent N8.46bn on debt service.

Edo State spent N75.78bn on recurrent expenditure but generated N52.68bn revenue. The state borrowed N12.84bn and spent N27.5bn on its debt service commitments.

Similarly, Ekiti State recurrent spending was N74.73bn, generated N23.16bn revenue, borrowed N11.75bn and spent N12.93bn to service its debts.

Enugu State spent N10.88bn on its operating expenses but got N39.98bn in revenue. This state borrowed N1.39bn and spent N6.93bn on its debt service.

Imo State, under Governor Hope Uzodinma, spent N42.75bn on its operating expenses but got N15.24bn as revenue. This state spent N15.94bn to service its debts but didn’t obtain any loan.

While Jigawa incurred N35.69bn as operating expenses, it collected N18.41bn as revenue out of its target of N50.65bn borrowed N744.75m, and N2.17bn on debt service.

Further analysis showed that Katsina State spent N40.73bn on its recurrent expenditure, while it generated revenue of N29.95bn. This state increased its loan by N72.89bn and paid N12.78bn as debt service.

Kebbi state recurrent spending was N22.42bn while it generated N7.86bn revenue. It also obtained an N24.59bn loan and paid debt service of N3.42bn.

Kogi State spent N84.48bn on its operating expenses but earned N19.86bn in revenue. The confluence state also obtained N51.68bn as loans and repaid N18.12bn debt.

Lagos state spending on recurrent expenses was N375.19bn, while it earned N912.15bn revenue. The state paid N84.53bn as debt service but didn't obtain any loan.

Within the same period, Nasarawa spent N42.63bn on its operating expenses but got N22.78bn as revenue, Niger state recurrent expenses reached N41.28bn while it earned N29.22bn.

Ondo State spent N107.34bn on recurring expenses but only earned N24.43bn, Osun State spent N48.87bn but earned N28.86bn as revenue while Oyo State spent N51.24 on its recurrent expenditure, N45.79bn was collected as revenue.

Plateau spent N144.86bn on its recurring expenses but only earned N18.03bn; Rivers State's spending on its operating costs was N72.69bn, but it earned N269.17bn.

Taraba state spending on recurrent expenditure reached N58.39bn, surpassing its revenue generation of N7.84bn, resulting in a deficit of N50.55bn. This state borrowed N52.63bn and paid N21.19bn.

Yobe State spent N51.29bn on its recurrent costs but earned N8.14bn as revenue. Also, Zamfara spent N36.34bn on its recurrent expenditure but earned N18.46bn.

Commenting in an interview, A professor of Economics at Babcock University, Segun Ajibola, stated that the enduring problem of high governance expenses had persisted at the state level, with inadequate oversight and accountability resulting in minimal economic benefits for grassroots citizens.

Ajibola, a former president of the Chartered Institute of Bankers, lamented that state assemblies had also abandoned their oversight duties, leaving the state governors to operate with no iota of transparency and accountability.

The Federal Government has commenced the payment of pensions and other entitlements to retired military personnel, including three months' arrears.

This was made public by the Minister of State for Defence, Bello Matawalle in a statement on Thursday in Abuja issued by the Director of Information and Public Relations, Ministry of Defence, Henshaw Ogubike.

Reports say retired military personnel halted activities at the Federal Ministry of Finance in Abuja on Thursday to protest their unpaid entitlements.

The retirees expressed frustration over the Federal Government's failure to pay the promised 20% to 28% salary increment from January to November 2024.

Their demands included overdue payments for palliatives from October 2023 to November 2024, an additional N32,000 added to their pensions, bulk payment of the Security Debarment Allowance, and the refund of pension deductions made from the salaries of medically boarded soldiers.

However, Matawalle said that the government has begun payment of military salary increases, and the military personnel have already started receiving alerts for the payment.

“President Bola Tinubu released funds for the payment of pension and other entitlements owed to retired military personnel on Thursday,” the statement said

He commended the President for his unwavering commitment to the welfare of both serving and retired military personnel, emphasising that the payment of pension arrears owed to retirees would continue to receive critical attention.

According to the minister, the initiative reflected the President’s dedication to enhancing the living standards of those who have served the nation.

Mayawalle also acknowledged the efforts and support of the Minister of Finance and Coordinating Minister of the Economy, Mr. Wale Edun, who was very committed to actualising the payments.

He urged the Nigerian military to remain steadfast in their duties, while reassuring them that the President was fully committed to boosting their morale and providing the necessary support to combat insecurity in Nigeria.

“In spite of initial setbacks, be rest assured that Mr President will do everything within his power to uplift our military forces as they confront the challenges of insecurity,” he said.

He expressed gratitude to the President for his decisive action and reiterated the vital role played by both retired and serving military personnel in ensuring the nation’s security and their significant contributions in combating insurgency.

He assured the Nigerian Armed Forces officers and personnel of the President’s unwavering resolve to eradicate insecurity in Nigeria, bolstered by the readiness and resilience of the military.

The African Development Bank Group has helped secure $2.2 billion in funding for the second phase of Nigeria’s Special Agro-Industrial Processing Zones initiative. This phase will build on the success of the first and aims to connect federal and state governments to key agricultural infrastructure.

The announcement was made at the Africa Investment Forum in Morocco, where Nigerian state governors, leaders from multilateral development organizations, diplomats, and private sector investors gathered to show their support. This ambitious initiative aims to transform Nigeria’s agricultural sector. Building on phase one, it will create agro-industrial hubs designed to boost productivity, improve food security, raise living standards, and generate jobs.

The bank reported that the boardroom session brought together top investors, including Arise IIP, the Arab Bank for Economic Development in Africa, Africa Export-Import Bank, Sahara Farms, BPI France, Africa50, and the US Development Finance Corporation. At the session's close, organizers revealed a total deal value of $2.2 billion, marking a major milestone in the development of SAPZ Nigeria Phase II.

Phase I of the program includes Nigerian states such as Cross River, Imo, Ogun, Oyo, Kaduna, Kwara, Kano, and the Federal Capital Territory. SAPZ Nigeria Phase II is now underway, with plans to expand to 24 states over the next three years. This phase will link Nigeria's agricultural sector to agro-industrialization to drive economic growth.

Dr. Abdul B. Kamara, the Bank's Director General for Nigeria, expressed his enthusiasm, stating, "I am pleased to see this whopping investment interest and commitments by our financing partners for Nigeria, at a time when the country is ramping up efforts to attract investments into the agriculture sector to address food security, create job opportunities and boost economic growth."

According to Dr. Akinwumi Adesina, President of the African Development Bank Group, "This is a defining moment for Nigeria's agricultural transformation. The Nigeria SAPZ II project will create millions of jobs, empower smallholder farmers, and position Nigeria as a leader in agro-industrialization. These investments exemplify the power of collaboration to achieve sustainable development in Africa."

The SAPZ Nigeria program is a nationwide, government-supported, private-sector-driven initiative aimed at transforming Nigeria's agricultural sector. Strategically located in regions with high agricultural potential, these zones are equipped with essential infrastructure, shared services, and policy incentives to attract and integrate both agricultural and industrial businesses. The African Development Bank Group remains dedicated to driving inclusive growth across Africa, with the Nigeria SAPZ II project showcasing its commitment to impactful, large-scale development through strategic partnerships.

A Former Chief Executive of Nigeria, Chief Olusegun Obasanjo, has zeroed in on the fact that the fight against corruption can only be effective and successful if it starts with accountability among top government authorities.

Chief Olusegun Obasanjo expressed that tackling corruption at the highest levels of leadership would set a model for other people and demonstrate the government's obligation to transparency and integrity.

The information was focused on Obasanjo's legacies in government and his evaluation of the present Nigeria.

Chief Olusegun Obasanjo portrayed corruption as hydra-headed and one that has eaten profound into the fabric of Nigerian society, underlining that the battle against corruption should begin with leadership for it to succeed.

"The best way of fighting corruption is starting from the head, that is where corruption has to be fought from," he stated.

The former President likewise presented that the battle against corruption should be a steady and day to day affair to stop it from ever really developing.

"Corruption is very hydra-headed and eats deep. I think it was the Sultan of Sokoto, the father of the present Sultan who said corruption is like a 'babariga', if you are folding it on one side, it's falling apart on the other side. When you carry it on both sides, you cannot hold your hands up and as soon as you put your hands down, it's falling apart.

"It's anything but a one-day issue. It's not a one-regime affair. It's not even a two-regime affair. Not only that, but it must be predictable. Not only that, but it must be non-stop. Furthermore, it has to be a daily affair. When one system is let off, it spreads."

He called for an adjustment in the recruitment and appointment of leaders into public offices, demanding that political appointments should be based on merit instead of political or tribal basis.

Speaking on the aspect of leadership, he said independent leaders or those enthroned by Satan will undoubtedly fizzle.

He stated that only God makes a leader, and whoever he ordains will succeed.

"So I will say most leaders are prepared by God, and they put in place by God and when that happens the chances of success are higher than when you make yourself a leader which may not be the act of God.

"What's more, again people saying all leaders are made by God, I don't acknowledge that. A leader can also be made by Satan. In the case of Job, you can remember Satan was going up and down and went before God and God was commending Job, but Satan said Job was upright to God because he has got from God.

"We must accept that Satan is real, and he has power, he has no salvation, but he has power and the power of Satan must not be underestimated."

About 70 lawyers have been employed by the Kano State Government as part of its effort to boost employment opportunities and strengthening the state's legal sector.

This was contained in a statement on Friday by the Director of Public Enlightenment, Office of the Head of Civil Service, Aliyu Yusuf, who said the initiative is aimed at improving service delivery within the Judiciary while addressing unemployment challenges in the state.

"The initiative by the governor will no doubt pave the way for the enhancement of effective service delivery in the legal sector of the state and at the same time address unemployment challenges," Yusuf said.

According to the statement, the Head of Service, Abdullahi Musa, supervised the final interviews of the candidates and commended the governor's visionary leadership.

He noted that this development would significantly bolster the state judiciary, which has long awaited such an intervention.

Addressing the newly employed lawyers, the HoS urged them to demonstrate integrity, dedication, selflessness, and a sense of accountability in the discharge of their responsibilities.

He also emphasised the importance of recognizing the competitive nature of the current job market and urged them to reciprocate the state's investment by being exemplary ambassadors.

"The recruitment drive reflects Kano State Government's ongoing efforts to empower its citizens and reinforce institutional capacity for sustainable development," the HoS was quoted as saying in the statement.

Former President Goodluck Jonathan, on Wednesday, arrived in Accra, Ghana, ahead of the December 7 general elections in the country as the leader of the delegation of the West African Elders Forum observation mission.

The WAEF's communications Officer, Wealth Dickson Ominabo, made this known in a statement made available to the News Agency of Nigeria on Wednesday in Abuja.

Ominabo, in the statement, quoted Jonathan on arrival in Ghana, as urging Ghanaians to be patriotic and work for peaceful, free and transparent elections.

Other members of the delegation include former Burkinabe Prime Minister and President of the ECOWAS, Mr Kadre Ouedraogo; Executive Director of the Goodluck Jonathan Foundation, Ms Ann Iyonu, and Special Adviser to Jonathan, Ikechukwu Eze.

Jonathan commended the people of Ghana for their enduring commitment to democratic values, adding that Ghana's history of peaceful political transitions served as a beacon for democratic governance across Africa.

"The upcoming elections present another opportunity for Ghanaians to reinforce their dedication to democracy, stability, and development," he stated.

The mission leaders also charged the electoral commission of Ghana and the security agencies to keep to their mandate of independence and neutrality to ensure a credible polling process.

He added, "WAEF urges the Electoral Commission of Ghana to uphold its mandate of conducting free and fair elections and ensuring the transparency and credibility of the 2024 elections as a way of building trust among the electorate and stakeholders.

“We encourage the security agencies to sustain their professional conduct, maintain their neutrality and a peaceful electoral environment by ensuring impartial deployment to safeguard voting materials, polling centres, and citizens across the country.

“As we approach the end of campaign activities, we urge all political parties and their candidates to reaffirm their commitment to peaceful campaigns devoid of hate speech, inflammatory rhetoric, and personal attacks.”

The former President also called on political parties, candidates and all stakeholders to respect the integrity of the electoral process and pledged to resolve disputes through lawful and constitutional channels.

Jonathan further urged the youth and party supporters to remain law-abiding during and after the elections, avoiding acts of intimidation or violence.

Describing Ghana as a model of democracy, Jonathan also urged Ghanaians to seek to safeguard Ghana’s democratic legacy by rejecting violence, intimidation, or actions that could undermine the integrity of the electoral process.

“By working together, Ghanaians can once again assert the country’s position as a model of democracy built on a tradition of peaceful, free, fair and transparent elections,” he said.

The Federal Government says President Bola Tinubu’s administration considers food security to be vital for his administration.

The Minister of State for Agriculture and Food Security Aliyu Abdullahi speaking, since Tinubu’s inauguration in May 2023, the government has carried out projects to guarantee food security in the country.

“As part of the Renewed Hope Agenda, since food security is on the front burner in the agriculture sector; it is the mainstream of Nigeria’s economy. It is expected to also play a critical role in the economy as a means of poverty alleviation and gender inclusivity,” the minister said.

“President Bola Ahmed Tinubu is genuinely concerned about our food security situation. Allow me add that many times he would say to us his vision is for us to take Nigeria to a position where no man goes to bed hungry. We have realized that and are working very hard to make sure we achieve that,” Abdullahi communicated.

Food prices have gone over the roof in recent years in Nigeria, pushing them past the limits of millions.

The Federal Government and state government have in the wake of the development introduced a raft of measures including the conveyance of palliative to millions of Nigerians.

Last year – only months after he assumed office – President Tinubu declared an emergency on food security.

“We will engage our security architecture to protect the farms and the farmers so that farmers can return to the farmlands without fear of attacks,” the president said.

Tinubu noted that the Central Bank of Nigeria will continue to play a part in financing the agricultural value chain. He said 500,000 hectares of land had been planned land to increase the accessibility of arable land for farming.